



FITNESSWISE

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From learning to leading

The transition from athlete to coach entails **exiting the known**, accepting the uncertain, and ultimately developing a new system tailored to the team's culture and needs.

Of the many soon-to-retire elite athletes worldwide, not everyone chooses to coach. And of those who do, not all will pursue it as a lifelong journey or become successful — let alone great — coaches. In the Indian context, a few examples include Rahul Dravid, Ravi Shastri, V. V. S. Laxman, Gautam Gambhir, Baskaran, P. T. Usha, P. Gopichand and Jaspal Rana, who have embarked on the difficult journey of coaching to train future players. Some continue to play and coach simultaneously — a rarity that reflects the player's commitment and the management's trust.

Some elite athletes and performers go into coaching to give back to their sport and to be a part of player development. Others do so because they have no other skills beyond knowing how to play their sport, or they have something else planned post-retirement. There are others who take it up because their sporting dream was cut short by deselection, a career-ending injury, or even politics.

The truth of the matter is that coaching positions are not open to all; selected individuals are recruited. Retired elites are headhunted to share their experience and wisdom, and to attract and inspire the next generation of players. There is often an inclination for their first job to be

either with the first team they played for or the last one. Anything that serves the teams well, as long as their culture is maintained.

People become coaches for many different reasons and in many different ways. But do those reasons also explain why they continue with it? Take cricket as an example, with pace bowling as a specific and specialised case. Not everyone is Dennis Lillee — the player who brought sports science to cricket way back in the early 1970s, far ahead of his time, and to a large extent, still is. His adaptation from playing to coaching, supported by a multi-level knowledge base from theory to practice, is a life lesson in itself. He established a cult-like coaching system for fast bowlers in India, which transformed the entire narrative around producing tearaway pace bowlers in the country.

I know a few coaches who, though armed with a thorough knowledge base in theory and research, have not been able to make the cut into the system due to various reasons. The transition may not be smooth, despite their well-developed knowledge. There are quite a few coaches who were recruited to coach the national team, and despite doing their due diligence before accepting the job, ended up saying adios to coaching — and the

sport altogether — within a year.

Others have quit coaching entirely because their wisdom did not translate into the desired results, or they were unable to comprehend or support someone else's dream. They may have been victims of circumstance, leading to an abrupt end to their careers — something that can continue to rankle in their minds and hinder their coaching philosophy.

Some cases are even more confusing — such as athletes who begin coaching immediately after retirement but soon decide to return to playing, and then retire again only to return to coaching, repeating the cycle on and on. This yo-yo effect can be frustrating, painful, and exhausting for any player-turned-coach.

I know of an early-career coach who screamed at his U19 players, telling them they were “ruining his reputation” after a below-par performance in a match. What reputation could the coach have when he had only been coaching for a few months? **Some retired elite athletes-turned-coaches struggle to work with athletes who are not like them — who do not share the same dreams, commitment, determination, or even physiology.** This represents a significant gap to be addressed.

The job insecurity and low